



AP PHOTO

Stamped Verdict

MUMBAI The Special Investigation Team (SIT) in the multi-crore fake stamp paper scam has suffered several setbacks. First, it was the acquittal of former Mumbai police commissioner R.S. Sharma charged with conniving with scam kingpin Abdul Karim Telgi. Now it is the revelation that the scam amounted to only Rs 200 crore instead of

the SIT's earlier estimate of Rs 30,000 crore. The case relates to the printing and sale of fake government stamps by a syndicate headed by Telgi.

A special court in Pune sentenced Telgi to 13 years' rigorous imprisonment along with a collective fine of Rs 202 crore after he pleaded guilty. A day earlier, Judge Chitra Bhedi discharged Sharma

SENTENCED: Telgi and DCP (Crime) Pradip Sawant and suspended Inspector Vashisht Andhale from the case for "lack of evidence."

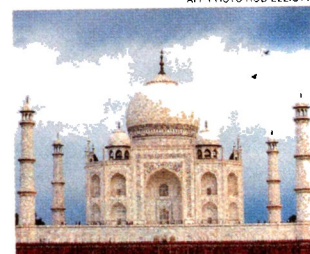
Interestingly, although the SIT implicated the three officials in the case, Telgi could be convicted only after these very officials were discharged. That's because in 2000, Sharma's team recovered Rs 2,200 crore worth fake stamp papers that were the only evidence against Telgi. "I was framed by some IPS officials whom I superseded," says Sharma, who was arrested before he took over as DGP in 2003. The court also sentenced 43 others accused to a minimum of five years after they pleaded guilty. Telgi is HIV positive and may not outlive his sentence.

by **Prerana Thakurdesai**

A Vote for Love

VARANASI With Agra's Taj Mahal's fate as one of the Seven Wonders of the World drawing closer, religion has surpassed barriers in this temple town with hundreds of sadhus promoting the monument of love's chances of making it into the list. Matted hair, unwashed bodies and saffron came together under the Akhil Bharatiya

AFP PHOTO ROB ELLIOTT



WONDER FULL: Taj Mahal Dharam Sangh in a march urging people to vote for Mughal emperor Shah Jahan's tribute to his wife Mumtaz Mahal with sadhus distributing pamphlets and holding aloft banners.

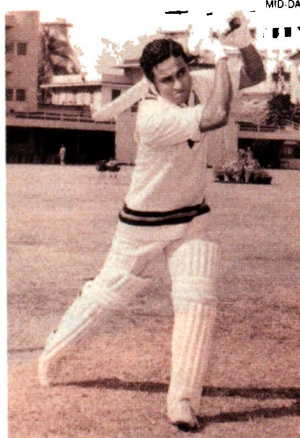
The Seven Wonders list will be announced in Lisbon on July 7 at an event to be co-hosted by Bollywood actor Bipasha Basu. Millions hope the majestic white marble mausoleum will be included in the list.

Congress President Sonia Gandhi and Tourism and Culture Minister Ambika Soni are among those who have campaigned for the Taj while A.R. Rahman has composed a song for it. The competition is organised by UNESCO and Bernard Weber, a Swiss-Canadian filmmaker and author. It allows people from across the world to choose from 21 monuments, narrowed down from a list of 177 in 2005.

by **Rahul Tewari**

OBITUARY

Dilip Narayan Sardesai, who died in Mumbai due to illness at the age of 66, will forever be associated with Indian cricket's coming of age and his part as architect and catalyst of India's twin triumphs in the West Indies and England in 1971. Sardesai was then at the end of his international career but that sign-off continues to echo in Indian cricket. On the 1971 West Indies tour, he made 642 runs, which included two centuries, including one in the famous Test win at Port of Spain and a double hundred in Jamaica. His batting on that tour inspired both a young debutant called S.M. Gavaskar as well as a local calypso. Five months later in England, he held up the middle-order in the final Test at the Kennington Oval which became India's first Test (and series) win in England. In the words of venerated cricket writer K.N. Prabhu, Sardesai gave Indian batting "form and substance".



MID-DAY

Dilip Sardesai 1940-2007

cricket with 10,230 runs, @41.75 with 25 centuries. After his playing days were done he served time as a Mumbai selector and an outspoken but open-hearted senior citizen of the game, remaining to the end, a stranger to cynicism or bitterness. He is survived by his wife and two children.

by **Sharda Ugra**